SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 3

Understanding Each Other

How we hear, see and belong to each other, at home and in every group



by Christian

Christian's Lab
spreadloveandacceptance.com

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Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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About this book, and how to use it

This book is about the people around you. It looks at how pace and tone pull people out of step, how words land, why two people remember the same moment differently, belonging and trust, love in its many forms, the pull of groups, and how to help someone without burning out.

It is for partners, families, friends, housemates and teams, and for anyone who has wondered why a kind conversation went wrong.

Read the chapters in any order. Each is a short version of a chapter that is free to read online, where the full version has more research, more examples and more to try. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

HERE	ABOUT	FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK
Chapter 1	Why we get out of tune	…/book/chapter-1
Chapter 2	How communication works	…/book/understanding-4-communication
Chapter 3	How we see each other	…/book/understanding-3-seeing
Chapter 4	Attachment, trust and belonging	…/book/understanding-5-belonging
Chapter 5	Closeness and love	…/book/understanding-15-love
Chapter 6	Groups, influence and culture	…/book/understanding-17-groups
Chapter 7	Helping others well	…/book/understanding-12-helping

There are four books in the series, and each stands on its own. The others are Book 1, *Know Yourself Kindly*, about yourself; Book 2, *Heal and Steady*, about the heavy days; Book 4, *Share the Load*, about sharing the work of a shared life. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 2, Chapter 1 (page 9)". The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on. Each line points to the chapter that helps most, and you can read that chapter on its own.

The same argument keeps coming back	Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune	9
Your messages keep landing wrong	Chapter 2 · How communication works	27
You remember the same day very differently	Chapter 3 · How we see each other	47
Trust feels shaky, or you fear being left	Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging	63
Closeness has faded	Chapter 5 · Closeness and love	81
A group pulls you along	Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture	97
Someone you love is struggling	Chapter 7 · Helping others well	115
You are running on empty from caring	Chapter 7 · Helping others well	115

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-09 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-09: Say it so it lands”. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Rhythms side by side”. You use it and it gives you something back.

Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Chapter 7, page **115** says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Book 2, Chapter 3, page 51 about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 1

Why we get out of tune: communication at home

Why two kind, reasonable people can end up in a tangle neither of them started, and how to get back in step.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. The tangle often isn't about the words
2. Nearly in step is the noisy part
3. Three things knock you out of tune
4. Stress changes your station
5. Nobody has to be wrong
6. Get back in tune before you carry on
7. Go back in with a clear sentence
8. Small daily check-ins keep you in tune
9. Faith, culture and family voices
10. On your own: your side of the tuning
11. One example, followed through
12. Common mix-ups

IN SHORT

- **A clash is often about how things were said.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- **Nobody has to be wrong.** Say that you are out of tune, pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- **Go back in with one clear sentence** that says what happened, how you feel and what you would like.
- **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

"I said I'd do it." "I know, I'm just asking when." Four sentences later nobody is talking about the bins any more, and neither of you could point to the moment it turned.

01

The tangle often isn't about the words.

Two people can each say something reasonable and still clash, because the tone underneath doesn't match. It is like two radios slightly out of tune, which together make a crackle that neither was making alone.

For example, one housemate asks whether anyone is using the oven tonight, and the other asks back whether she left a mess. A plain question has been heard as a complaint.

YOU COULD SAY

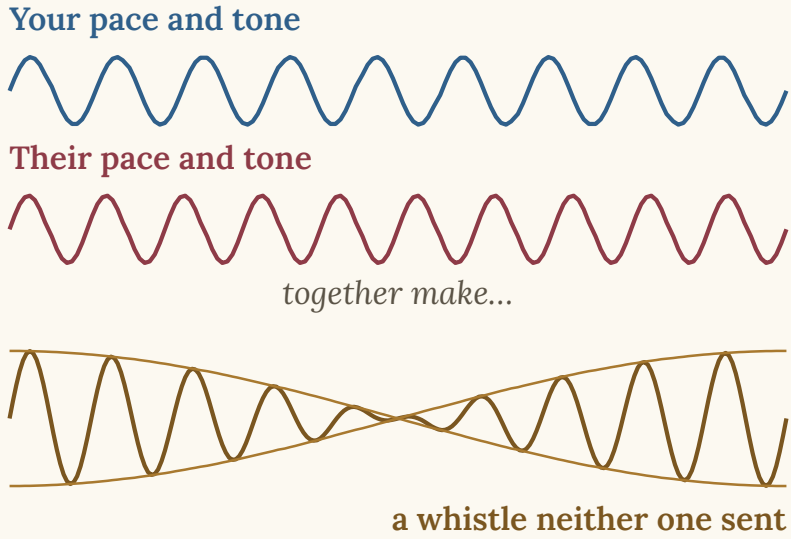
"I think the words were fine. Something in how we said them got crossed."

TRY THIS.

After your next small clash, ask yourself whether it was the words or the way they came out.

The radio whistle

Two reasonable signals, nearly in step.



Not “you started it” or “I started it”.
It started, between us.

Illustration. The picture is borrowed from radio (a “beat” between two close frequencies). Using it for people is this book’s idea.

FIGURE 1 The radio whistle. Two reasonable signals, nearly in step, can make a clash that neither person started: it started between you.

02

Nearly in step is the noisy part.

Radios on very different stations don’t whistle at each other. The whistle comes when they are close but not quite matched, which is why people who know each other well can still clash. Research suggests we check our meaning less with people we are close to, because we assume they already understand us.

Two sisters who talk every day argue about holiday plans far more often than either does with the cousins they see once a year.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I think I assumed you knew what I meant. Let me say it more clearly."

THIS WEEK.
With someone close to you, check one meaning today, with "Just so I've got it right, you mean…?"



TIDBIT
Ooh, Tidbit loves this one: compare your daily rhythms and see whose engine runs fast in the morning and whose at night. Different speeds aren't wrong, just different!

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Rhythms side by side
spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration

03

Three things knock you out of tune.

The first is how fast you are talking. The second is tone, as when a simple update is heard as a complaint. The third is how urgent something feels, since "when you get a chance" can mean tonight to one person and next week to another. Texts lose most of their tone, which makes urgency especially easy to misread.

For example, a business partner texts “Need to talk” between two meetings. The other partner reads it as a crisis and lies awake until two in the morning, and in the end it turns out to be about the printer.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> “By when would be good?” “Is this an update, or a worry?”

> ONE SMALL STEP.
> Add a time to your next request, so that “at some point” becomes “by Friday”.

04

Stress changes your station.

When you are tense, you may talk faster and be more likely to hear a pause as a snub. When you are tired and flat, your replies get slower and shorter. The Nervous System Ladder, a thirty-second self-check, gives you a best guess at which state you are in.

A dad gets home from a night shift and answers his teenage son in single words. His son decides that he doesn’t care, when he is simply running on empty.

> WORDS TO TRY
> “I’m running low right now, and it isn’t about you. Can we talk after I’ve slept?”

> SOMETHING TO TRY.
> Before a tricky talk, name your state to yourself as calm, revved up or running on empty.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
The Nervous System Ladder
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

05

Nobody has to be wrong.

Two radios that both work perfectly will still crackle if they are slightly off, and arguing about whose fault the static is won't clear it. Retuning, which means getting back in step, will.

For example, a grandmother tells her grown-up son that he looks tired. She means it as care, and he hears that he isn't coping, so both of them are right about what they meant and what they heard.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I don't think either of us meant it that way. Can we try that again?"

TRY THIS.
In your next clash, try "we" in place of "you", as in "We got crossed there."

06

Get back in tune before you carry on.

Say out loud that you think you are out of sync, and check how tense you feel. Either of you can call a pause, and whoever pauses names a time to come back. Slow down gently, with shorter turns and more pauses, and only then go back to the actual topic.

Two roommates in halls agree on a pause word, “static”, on a calm day. In the middle of an argument about noise one of them says it, and they stop and come back at nine as agreed.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

“I need ten minutes. I’ll come back at half past.”

THIS WEEK.

Agree a pause word with someone today, while you are both calm.

07

Go back in with a clear sentence.

When you return to the topic, say what happened, how you feel and what you would like. “The bins go out early on Wednesday morning. I get anxious when they’re late. Could you put them out tonight?”

For example, a co-parent texts, “The swim kit wasn’t in the bag and I felt stressed at drop-off. Could you pack it on Sunday nights?”

ONE SMALL STEP.

Write one sentence like that about something small, before you need it.

Retuning, step by step

Before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

1. **Name the mismatch, without blame**
   "I think we're on different wavelengths."
2. **Check your own state**
   Revved up or running on empty? Pause, and name a time to come back.
3. **Slow the pace on purpose**
   Shorter turns, more pauses, a lower voice.
4. **Then go back to the topic**
   It still matters. Now you can both hear it.

This book's four steps. Anyone can call a pause, and nobody should be blocked from leaving the room.

FIGURE 2 Retuning, step by step, before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When you go back in, one clear sentence beats a speech. This workpaper helps you shape it before you say it.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-09 · free to print
Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

08

Small daily check-ins keep you in tune.

A short chat each day, like the 90-second daily check-in, makes tiny corrections before small things drift into a big argument. Habit research suggests small routines at a regular time are easier to keep than big ones done rarely. The quiet, easy stretches are the ones that drift most, so keep it going even when nothing seems wrong (see Complacency).

A long-distance couple in two time zones send each other one 90-second voice note every morning, and on the weeks they forget, they notice the difference by Thursday.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "Today I was carrying quite a lot. One thing I liked today was…"

SOMETHING TO TRY.
Pick a time and a cue, such as straight after dinner, and try the check-in for three days.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The 90-second daily check-in

Priya and Dev, a couple on different shifts

The 90-second daily check-in

Person A
Priya

Person B
Dev

Week beginning
5 October 2026

Each day

Day	Person	Load	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Mon	*Priya*	*High*	*You left soup in the fridge before my night shift*	*Woke up to the washing still in the machine*	*A text when you're leaving work*
Mon	*Dev*	*Medium*	*Your note on the kettle*		*Bins out before I go at six*
Tue	*Priya*	*High*	*You kept the house quiet till noon*		*Ten minutes together at the shift change*
Tue	*Dev*	*Low*	*You booked the car in*	*Missed you at dinner again*	
Wed	*Priya*	*Medium*	*Breakfast together at 8*		*Early night*

Day	Person	Load	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Wed	*Dev*	*Medium*	*You remembered my mum's call*		

LOAD THIS WEEK

Priya
2 high, 1 medium, 0 low

Dev
0 high, 2 medium, 1 low

The weekly catch-up

Sore spot that keeps coming up	Times this week	Move to
Washing left in the machine	2	*One owner per job*
Missing each other at dinner	2	*Keep watching*

One sentence each, then just listen: no debating, no solving.

Fill in your own: The 90-second daily check-in

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-13 · free to print
The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13

ONLINE
Complacency
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency

WORKPAPER WP-13 · free to print
The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control what you send, whether you check how it landed, and whether you step out to retune. You don't control how it's heard or how fast the other person settles. Matching energy here means matching care and effort, never volume: if someone gets louder, you don't have to follow. Stay at your level, and give the conversation the energy it gives back. More in Book 1, Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

SATURDAY, 10AM

One of you says the spare room needs clearing out at some point. She meant this month, and he heard today and has already cancelled his plans in his head. By lunchtime you are both upset about a room nobody has touched, and when you stop to ask what "at some point" meant, you find you are still not sure you agree.

Faith, culture and family voices

For many couples, faith is where they turn first, and a shared faith can be one of the strongest tools for staying in tune. Praying together, or a quiet moment after worship, can serve as a daily check-in. Some couples each pray on their own before they come back to a hard talk, with the pause still ending at a named time. A pastor, imam, rabbi, priest or trusted elder can be a good first person to talk to, and many can suggest a trained counsellor who shares your faith.

Emeka and Ngozi, married for twenty-six years, do their monthly look-back on a Sunday after church, over lunch. When a talk gets

heated, either of them can say, “Let’s pray on it and come back at eight,” and they do.

Culture shapes how you talk too. In many families, respect for elders decides who can speak plainly to whom, and one habit helps a great deal, which is that each of you speaks to your own parents and relatives once you have agreed the message together.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> “Can we pray about this and talk again tonight?” “Mum, we love you, and we’ve thought about it carefully. This year we’ll visit in August instead of at Easter.”

From two faiths or cultures? See Two faiths or cultures, one family.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Two faiths or cultures, one family
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths

On your own: your side of the tuning

Getting out of tune takes two, but retuning can start with one. You can learn your own pace, tone and sense of urgency, so you notice when you are the one running fast or slow. Learn your early signs of drifting, such as a tight chest, a clipped reply or the wish to win. Learn how you take words in best and say it once, as in “I hear things better in writing.” When you drift, step out, settle and come back, which you can do without anyone’s permission. Hamid lives

alone and has noticed that his texts to friends come out short when he is tired, so now he waits until morning to answer anything that matters (more in On my own).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/on-my-own

One example, followed through

Cerys, Marisol and Dougie share a house and a car, and two of them talk fast while the third, Dougie, talks slowly. At house meetings Dougie kept getting talked over, and for a while the other two read his silence as agreement. It came out in March, when he said he had never actually agreed to the new car rota. They tried a simple change, a round in which each person speaks once before anyone answers. It felt stilted at first, and Cerys kept wanting to jump in. By the third meeting Dougie was saying more, and the rota he suggested is the one they now use. They still have the occasional evening when the meeting turns into two fast talkers and one quiet one, and someone usually says “round” to reset it. Help by relationship has pages for many other kinds of shared life.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/by-relationship

Common mix-ups

- **"Retuning means giving in."** You still come back to the topic, at a time when you can hear each other.
- **"If we're out of sync, one of us must be wrong."** Two fair points in two different tones can still clash.
- **"A pause means the topic is dropped."** A pause always comes with a time to come back.

To try it, agree on a shared phrase while things are calm, such as "I think we're out of tune", so that it works as a signal when you need it. For one week, each of you can note one moment you felt out of step, and at the end you can compare whether it was mostly pace, tone or urgency. Rewind the talk, Say it so it lands and the 90-second daily check-in are free on the site.

A limit to keep in mind: These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking things through ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A pause is for both of you. If one person is never allowed to pause, or a "pause" is used to punish with days of silence, that isn't retuning. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

WORKPAPER WP-09 · free to print
Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

WORKPAPER WP-13 · free to print
The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

ONLINE
Signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · How communication works page 27
How meaning, tone and listening work

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system Heal and Steady, page 9
Why stress speeds people up or shuts them down

Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words Know Yourself Kindly, page 25
How you like to be spoken to

Book 1, Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently Know Yourself Kindly, page 115
When pace and tone are a wiring difference

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 1
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

The 90-second daily check-in
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1-in-depth

2

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 2

How communication works: meaning, listening, repair and messages

Talking feels simple because we do it all day, yet every message has to travel from one mind to another, and a lot can change on the way. This chapter follows that journey and looks at what helps a message arrive the way you meant it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Meaning is made between two people
2. Every message says two things
3. Listening is something you do, not something that happens
4. Check, don't guess
5. Hard things land better when they start soft
6. Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill
7. Messages lose their tone on the way
8. Different styles aren't wrong styles
9. Small talk has a job, and it can be short
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Three tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **Say it so it lands** (Book 4, Chapter 4 (page 71)) asks for what happened, how you feel and one clear request, because every message carries its content and a second message about the relationship.

- **The 90-second daily check-in** (Chapter 1 (page 9)) works because mix-ups are normal, and small, frequent repairs keep people in tune better than rare big talks.
- **The Chat analyzer's whole-conversation view** shows where a written conversation lost its tone.

THURSDAY, 8:15AM

Ana texts her brother to ask him to call when he is free. She means there's no rush and she has a small question about the weekend. He reads it on the bus and spends the whole ride wondering who is ill.

Small habits help a message arrive, such as listening, checking, starting softly and repairing quickly, and a few ready-made lines make small talk easier for anyone who dreads it.

01

Meaning is made between two people.

Words don't carry meaning on their own. The speaker has a meaning in mind, and the listener builds their own from the words, the tone, the timing and everything they already expect. Most of the time the two match well enough, and sometimes they don't, without either person being able to see the gap from where they stand.

For example, a manager writes "Let's chat tomorrow" to a new coworker, meaning a friendly catch-up, and he spends the evening convinced he is in trouble.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think what I meant and what you heard might be two different things. Can we check?"

TRY THIS.

Today, notice one moment when someone took your words differently from how you meant them, and leave blame out of it.

02

Every message says two things.

There is *what* you say, and there is what it says about the two of you. "You're late" is a fact about time, and it can also mean "I was worried" or "I don't matter to you." People often argue about the fact when the hurt is in the second layer.

When one housemate asks another whether she used his pan, the question is about a pan and also, underneath, about whether his things are respected, which no amount of talk about the pan will settle.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I don't really mind about the pan. I think I wanted to know my stuff matters here."

THIS WEEK.

Next time a small thing stings, ask yourself what it seemed to say about *us*.

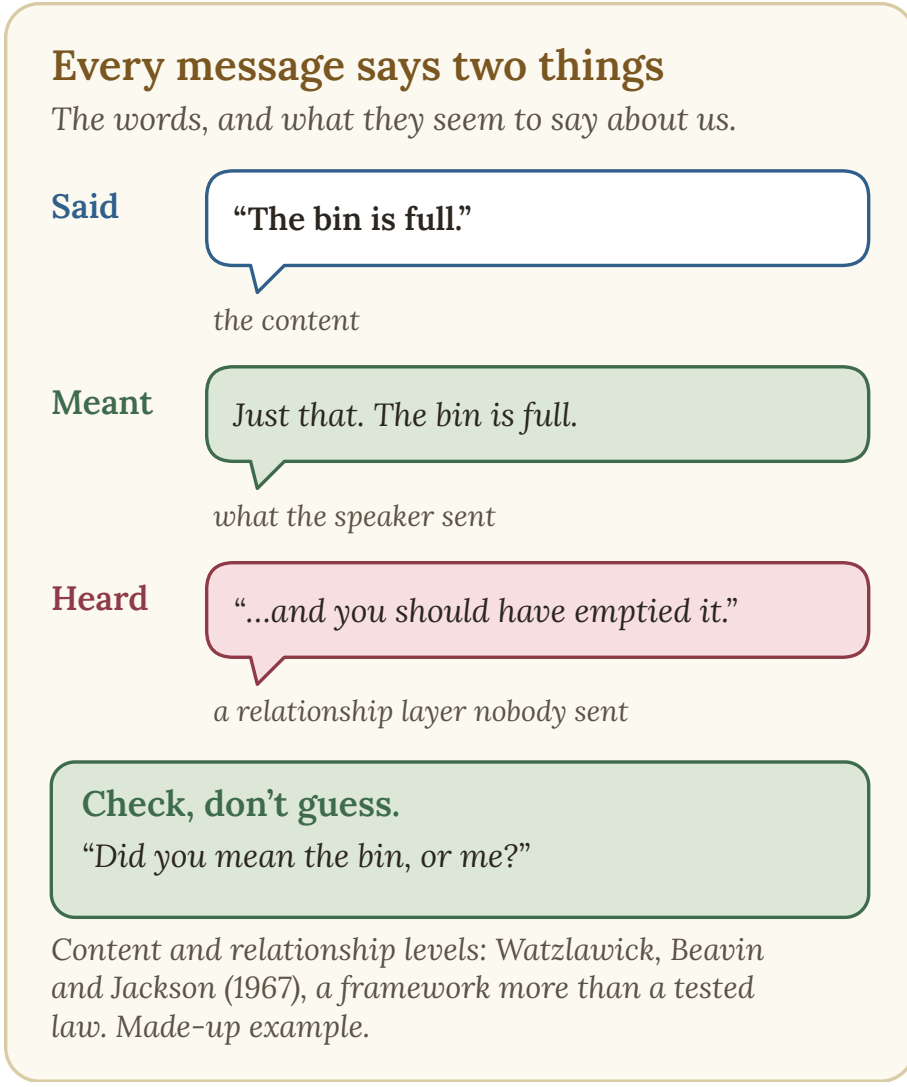


FIGURE 3 Every message says two things: the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you. Check, don't guess.

03

Listening is something you do, not something that happens.

Hearing happens by itself, while listening is a choice. Most of us listen partly to reply, so that we can fix, defend, advise or tell our own story. Real listening means following what the other person is

trying to say and letting them know you got it before you add anything of your own.

For example, a teenager says school is pointless, her dad starts explaining why it isn't, and she stops talking. The next time she says it, he asks, "Pointless how? Tell me about today," and she talks for twenty minutes.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"So what I'm hearing is... Have I got that right?" "Do you want ideas, or do you want me to just listen?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

In one conversation today, wait until the other person has finished, then say back what you heard before you reply.

04

Check, don't guess.

Once we know something, it is hard to imagine not knowing it, so we leave out steps, assume the other person can tell what we mean and guess what they meant instead of asking. We do this most with the people we know best. A short check costs a sentence, while a wrong guess can cost a whole evening.

Two friends plan something low-key for a birthday. One pictures a takeaway on the sofa and the other books a quiet restaurant, and both are disappointed because each thought it was obvious.

WORDS TO TRY

"Just so I've got it right, you mean...?" "When you say soon, do you mean today or this week?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Pick one person you know well and check one meaning with them today, even if you feel sure.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Checking takes ten seconds and saves an evening. When you're ready to reply, this workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-09 · free to print
Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

05

Hard things land better when they start soft.

How a hard talk begins often shapes how it ends. A complaint about one thing ("The bins weren't taken out") is easier to hear than a criticism of the person ("You never help"). A simple shape works for most hard things, which is to say what happened, how you feel and what you would like.

For example, a woman wants her elderly father to stop driving at night. She leaves out "You're not safe any more" and says, "You had two near-misses last month and I lie awake worrying. Could I drive us in the evenings?"

YOU COULD SAY

"What happened was... I felt... Could we...?"

TRY THIS.

Write one sentence in that shape about something small that has been bothering you. You don't have to send it yet.

Say it so it lands

A simple shape for most hard things.

What happened
One specific fact, not a verdict.
"The bins didn't go out on Tuesday."

How I feel
Your feeling, in a word or two.
"I felt let down, because I'd asked."

What I'd like
A small, doable ask.
"Could you set a reminder for next week?"

✕ **Not: "You never help."**
That's about the person, so it starts a defence.

This book's plain-language shape, a cousin of I-messages and Nonviolent Communication; research on such scripts is mixed, and tone matters most.

FIGURE 4 Say it so it lands: what happened, how I feel, what I'd like. A complaint about an action can be heard; a criticism of the person starts a defence.

06

Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.

Even close, kind people misunderstand each other all the time. What keeps a relationship steady is noticing and fixing it with lines like “That came out wrong”, “I think I misread you” or “Can we start again?”, and small repairs made often build trust.

At the supermarket a stranger snaps “Excuse me!” when you block the aisle, and you snap back. A second later you add, “Sorry, long day,” and she smiles and says the same is true for her.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> “Can I try that again?” “I think I took that the wrong way. What did you mean?”

THIS WEEK.

The next time something comes out wrong, repair it out loud within a minute, and notice how small a repair can be.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot’s tip: a mix-up isn’t the end of anything. Come back, sit close, and go through it step by step.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Rewind the talk
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`

07

Messages lose their tone on the way.

A text or email carries the words without your face, your voice or your timing, so the reader fills in the tone with however *they* feel right now, and a tired reader hears a tired, cross message. Short replies, missing greetings and late-night timing all get read as meaning something.

For example, in the group chat for a school fundraiser, one parent replies "Fine." to a plan, and two others decide she is annoyed, when she was typing one-handed while stirring a pan of soup.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Quick reply, not a cross one!" "This isn't urgent. Any time this week is fine."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Before you send your next tricky message, read it out loud in the grumpiest voice you can. If it sounds harsh, add a warm word or a time frame.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL

Chat analyzer

spreadloveandacceptance
.com/signal-translator

08

Different styles aren't wrong styles.

Some people say exactly what they mean and others hint and expect you to read between the lines. Some talk fast and overlap while others need a pause to think. Families, cultures and different kinds of minds all shape this, and a clash between two styles is usually a matter of translation.

Asked whether the report is ready, an autistic employee says, "No, I need two more days." Her manager hears bluntness until they talk about it, after which he starts to find her clarity a relief.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

Chat analyzer: a whole conversation (once called the Conversation Reader)

Dana and Raj, coworkers on the same project

Chat analyzer: paste a conversation

01 Paste the conversation

Dana: Did the slides go to the client?
Raj: Not yet, still waiting on the numbers from finance
Dana: I needed them by 10. This always happens.
Raj: I can't make finance go faster.
Dana: Forget it. I'll do it myself.

02 Which one is you?

Dana (3 messages) Raj (2 messages)

03 THE READ

What happened
Ends shut down. 5 messages: 3 from you, 2 from Raj. The words don't make it clear what it's mostly about, so the Reader won't guess. It starts calm. There's no one big turn, but some tension creeps in. By the end someone has pulled back. That isn't the same as calm: it can mean they're overwhelmed, or hurt.

Your part · always / never
I said "This always happens", and that isn't fair: it isn't every time. What I meant was: [one recent time, and how it felt].

04 Check your reply before you send it

Your reply
Sorry, that last line wasn't fair. When the numbers weren't in by 10, I felt worried about the client. Could you ask finance for them by 9 next time? I'll chase them with you.

THE CHECK

✓ Says what you need or how it landed · ✓ Makes one clear ask · ✓ No verdicts, always/never, dismissals, sarcasm, jabs, comparisons or shutting the door · ✓ Stays on one topic

Nothing in the wording is likely to add heat. Read it once more as if you were them, then send it when you're calm.

The Reader looks at one side's part without blaming anyone.
Fill in your own: Chat analyzer

WORDS TO TRY

"I'm quite direct, so if I sound blunt, it doesn't mean I'm cross."
"It helps me if you say exactly what you need."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Write one sentence about how you like to be spoken to, and share it with one person this week.

09

Small talk has a job, and it can be short.

Small talk ("Cold today, isn't it?" "Busy weekend?") isn't really about the weather. Its job is to say that you see the other person and that the two of you are okay. In 1923 the anthropologist Bronisław Malinowski called this "phatic communion", talk whose main purpose is bonding more than information. Small moments like this matter more than people expect. Sandstrom and Dunn (2014) found that people who had a short, friendly exchange with a coffee-shop barista felt more belonging and a better mood than people who kept it purely efficient.

Small talk is hard work for many people, though, including many autistic people, shy or anxious people and people speaking a second language. The rules are unwritten, it can feel pointless and it uses energy. A few ready-made lines, sometimes called social scripts, take the guesswork out, and keeping it short is allowed.

For example, a dad who dreads the school gate keeps three lines ready, starting with "Morning! How's your week going?", then "Oh, nice," and finally "Right, I'd better get going. See you Friday." Some mornings he still hides in the car until the bell, but most days he gets through it.

YOU COULD SAY

"Morning! How's your week been?" "How do you know Nico?" "Oh, how was that?" "Lovely to see you. I'd better get on." And to opt out kindly, "I'm not great at chit-chat, but it's really nice to see you."

TRY THIS.

Write your own three lines, one to open, one follow-up question and one to close, and use them once this week. If you would rather skip ahead to a real topic, "Can I ask you about something I'm actually curious about?" works too.

THURSDAY, 9:02AM

Ana's brother rings the moment he is off the bus and asks who is ill. She laughs and says nobody, she only wanted to know whether he is free on Saturday, and he laughs too, a little shakily. The following week her text reads, "No rush and nothing's wrong. Quick question about Saturday, call when you're free."

In everyday life

On your own: how you talk to yourself

You also send yourself messages all day, from "Typical, I always mess this up" to "That was hard, and I handled it." The same ideas apply, so notice the tone, check whether the message is fair and repair it when it is harsh. Catch one harsh sentence you say to yourself today and rewrite it the way you would speak to someone you like.

With other people

Between partners, "We never go out any more" sounds like a complaint about evenings, and underneath it may mean "I miss you," so answering that layer goes further than defending the calendar. "Stop that!" tells a child what not to do without saying what to do instead, while "Feet on the floor, please" is easier to

follow. In meetings, silence is often taken as agreement until a quieter colleague says later that she never agreed, and a round of "Anyone see it differently?" catches this early. "Are you eating properly?" is care in one generation's language and checking up in another's.

- **Feedback at work.** Talk about the work, not the person, with one recent example and what good looks like. Then ask, "What's been getting in the way?" When you're the one receiving it, "Thanks. Can I think about it and come back tomorrow?" is a fine first answer. More, with a performance conversation.

Common mix-ups

- **"If they loved me, they'd just know."** Closeness makes us check *less* without making us understand more, so saying it clearly is a kindness.
- **"Listening means agreeing."** You can fully understand someone and still see it differently, and understanding comes first.
- **"Repairing means admitting I'm the bad one."** A repair just says that it didn't go the way you wanted, and either person can make one.
- **"Texts are safer for hard things."** They feel safer to send and are easier to misread, so for tender things, add warmth or talk.

If you want to help someone else with this

Maybe a friend keeps having the same argument with their partner, or your teenager feels nobody listens. You can't

communicate for them, but you can help.

- **Listen first.** The most useful thing is often to be the person who really hears them, without fixing.
- **Help them separate the two layers**, by asking what it was about and what it seemed to say about the two of them.
- **Offer the simple shape** of what happened, how they feel and what they would like, and let them find their own words.
- **Stay out of judging the other person's character.** You only hear one side, and they may make up next week.
- **Notice if it's more than a mix-up.** If they seem afraid of the other person, gently share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "Do you want me to just listen, or help you think about what to say?"

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

When to get more help

Most mix-ups can be eased with the ideas here. Some situations need more.

- **When talking makes things worse every time,** a couples or family counsellor can slow conversations down and help both

people be heard.

- **When you're afraid of how someone will react,** that isn't a communication problem. Clearer words are not the fix, and you don't have to keep trying. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help, and signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs) may help you name what's happening.
- **When someone is always "misunderstanding" you** in ways that make you doubt your memory or your sense of what happened, talk with someone you trust outside the relationship.
- **When speaking or understanding is hard for you every day,** because of anxiety, a hearing or language difference, or how your mind works, a doctor, speech and language therapist or counsellor may help. Needing support is not a failing.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

ONLINE
signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Try one of these this week with one real conversation. Say it so it lands helps you shape a hard sentence, Rewind the talk walks you back through a talk that went wrong, and the wiring card puts how you communicate on one page.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-09 · free to print
Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

TOOL
How you connect: how to talk to me
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Chat analyzer: calm replies after a fight.
- Communication style quiz: a playful look at your own style.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Chat analyzer
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

ONLINE
Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

More for your situation

- At work: messages and meetings
- Friends
- For teens and for parents
- Co-parenting
- Sharing a room
- Long distance
- Two faiths or cultures, one family
- Neurodivergent relationships: communication

- Find it by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
At work: messages and meetings
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
for parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents

TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

ONLINE
Long distance
spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance

ONLINE
Two faiths or cultures, one family
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships: communication
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Find it by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Meaning is made between two people.** What you say and what they hear can differ without either of you being wrong.
- ✓ **Every message says two things**, the words themselves and what they seem to say about the two of you.
- ✓ **A short question saves a long misunderstanding**, so check before you guess.
- ✓ **Mix-ups are normal, and repairing them is the skill.** Small talk is allowed to be short.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune page 9
Pace, tone and getting back in tune

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair Share the Load, page 71
Letting a comment land

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt Heal and Steady, page 89
Repair after it goes wrong

Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words Know Yourself Kindly, page 25
How you like to be spoken to

PUT IT TO USE

Chat analyzer
Calm replies after a fight
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

Communication style quiz
A playful look at your own style
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication-in-depth

3

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 3

How we see each other: perception, bias, and the stories we tell

Why two people can watch the same moment and come away with two different stories, and how to see others, and yourself, a little more fairly.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Seeing is a best guess
2. You see what you're looking for
3. We fill the gaps with stories
4. We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions
5. Quick shortcuts can lead us astray
6. Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly
7. "Us" and "them" changes what we see
8. Ask, don't guess
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Seeing is a best guess.** Your brain fills in a lot of what you think you see and hear.
- **We fill gaps with stories**, and the story often feels like a fact.
- **We judge ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions**, and that gap causes a lot of hurt.

- **Asking is kinder and more accurate** than trying to read someone's mind.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Three tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **Who did what** (Book 4, Chapter 1 (page 9)) works because everyone sees their own effort more clearly than other people's, so two honest guesses of "I do about 60%" can add up to more than 100%. Writing it down replaces two guesses with one shared page.
- **Rewind the talk** (Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51)) slows down the habit of judging ourselves by our reasons and other people by their actions.
- **The Chat analyzer** follows this chapter's last idea, that asking works better than guessing.

WEDNESDAY, 12:15PM

You wave at a coworker across the canteen, and she looks straight through you and walks off. All afternoon you wonder what you did, until at four o'clock she messages to say sorry for not stopping, because she had just had a call about her dad. She never saw you wave.

How feelings work (Book 1, Chapter 4, page 61) and Stress and the nervous system (Book 2, Chapter 1, page 9) look inward. This chapter looks outward, at how we see other people, why misunderstandings are so common even between kind and clever people, and what helps.

01

Seeing is a best guess.

Your eyes and ears take in far less than you think, and your brain fills in the rest from what it expects. Most of the time this works well and fast, but it means that what you see is partly what you expected to see, so two people can watch the same moment and honestly see different things.

For example, two parents watch their son in a football match. One sees him giving up, and the other sees him being careful with the ankle he twisted last week.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
>
> "This is what I see, and there may be more to it." "What else could this be?"

TRY THIS.

Next time you're sure what someone meant by a look, think of two other things it could have meant.

02

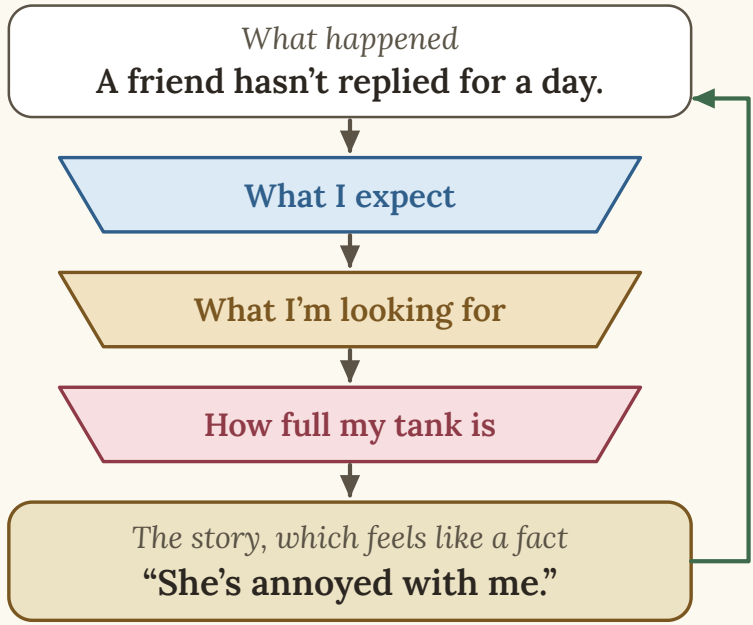
You see what you're looking for.

Attention is like a torch in a dark room. You see what it lights up and can miss what it doesn't, even when it is right in front of you. If you are looking for proof that someone doesn't care, you will notice every missed call and none of the little kindnesses.

A woman decides that her new manager doesn't like her, and for a month she notices every short email he sends. She misses the fact that he gave her the best project on the team.

Seeing is a best guess

What happened passes through filters before it becomes "what I saw".



Ask, don't guess.
"*Is everything okay?*"
Her phone broke.

Illustration. The brain fills gaps from what it expects ("predictive processing", an influential idea, still debated).

FIGURE 5 Seeing is a best guess. The story that comes out feels like a fact; asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"What might I be missing?" "If I were looking for the opposite, what would I see?"

THIS WEEK.

For one week, write down one kind thing that a person you are struggling with does each day.

03

We fill the gaps with stories.

When we don't know why someone did something, the mind makes up a reason fast. A late reply becomes anger and a closed door becomes rejection, and the story arrives feeling like a fact. Memory works this way too, because each time we remember something we rebuild it a little, so two people can honestly remember the same evening differently.

For example, a friend doesn't reply for two days and you decide she is fed up with you. She was camping in Snowdonia with no signal.

YOU COULD SAY

"The story I'm telling myself is that you're upset with me. Is that right?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

When something someone did hurts, write down the story you are telling yourself, and then one other possible story.

04

We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions.

When you are late, you know why, whether it was the traffic, a phone call or a child who lost a shoe. When someone else is late, you only see the lateness, and it is easy to decide they are careless. We all tend to blame other people's character for things that are really about their situation.

A driver cuts in front of you and you call him an idiot under your breath. The next week, rushing to the hospital, you cut someone up yourself, and you know exactly why.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"What might be going on for them that I can't see?" "If I did this, what would my reason be?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

When someone annoys you today, think of one situation that would explain it without making them a bad person.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

We know our own reasons and only see other people's actions. Writing out their side, in their words, is a fair way to even that up.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

Quick shortcuts can lead us astray.

The brain uses shortcuts to save time, and many are useful. Some lead to unfair judgements, such as a first impression that colours everything after it, a bad moment that outweighs ten good ones, or a quick guess about someone from their age, accent, looks or

group. Everyone has these shortcuts, and the trouble starts when nobody notices them.

For example, a housemate decides on the first day that the new tenant is messy because of one box left in the hall. Every bit of mess after that counts as proof, while her own goes unseen.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Am I looking for proof of what I already think?" "Would I judge this the same if someone I like did it?"

TRY THIS.

Pick one person you've made your mind up about. Look for one thing that doesn't fit your view of them.

06

Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly.

Most of us feel that we see things as they really are and that anyone who disagrees must be missing something, biased or not thinking straight. The other person feels exactly the same about you, and each of you can see the other's lens more easily than your own.

Two adult siblings argue about how their parents raised them, and each insists they are just being realistic, which is true of what each of them lived through.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think we're both seeing this from where we stand. Can you tell me how it looks from yours?"

THIS WEEK.

In your next disagreement, explain the other person's view back to them until they agree that you have got it, and then give yours.

07

"Us" and "them" changes what we see.

People split into groups quickly, even over tiny things. We tend to see our own group as varied and full of individuals and other groups as all the same, and we give our own side the benefit of the doubt. Spending real time with people from the other group, as equals, is one of the best ways to soften this.

For example, at one depot the night shift calls the day shift lazy and the day shift calls the night shift sloppy. After a joint training day, people start using each other's names.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Would I say this about one of 'us'?" "Who in that group do I actually know?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Have one real conversation this month with someone from a group you tend to see as "other", and ask about their day before you ask about their views.

08

Ask, don't guess.

Imagining yourself in someone's shoes is a kind start, though research suggests it doesn't make us much more accurate about what they think, while asking does. A simple, curious question like "What was that like for you?" works better than the cleverest guess.

A grandmother thinks her teenage grandson hates visiting because he is always on his phone. When she asks, she finds he is messaging a friend who is having a hard time, and that he likes being at her house because it is calm.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Can I check what you meant?" "What was going on for you?" "I might have this wrong. How did it look from your side?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Once today, swap a guess for a question.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Chat analyzer (also called the Signal Translator)

Zoe, texting her oldest friend, who moved abroad

Chat analyzer

Mode

I'm about to send this Someone sent me this

Type your sentence

You always cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

Relationship

Friends

Channel

Text / chat

THE READ

How it may land for most listeners
Some words may hurt. How it may sound: sharp in places.

What stands out
The word “always” (words like “always” and “never” leave no room for the times it went fine).

A clearer way to say it
Lately it’s felt like you cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

What changed, and why
always → lately it’s felt like. “Always” and “never” erase every exception, so the listener argues the exception.

The ask stayed; only the word that would start an argument changed.

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Chat analyzer
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/signal-translator

THURSDAY, 12:20PM

You see your coworker in the canteen again, and this time you go over and ask how her dad is. She tells you about the hospital and the waiting, and you end up sharing a table until the end of the break.

In everyday life

We tell stories about ourselves too, and "I always mess things up" is usually built from a few bright memories that leave a great deal out. After years together, partners stop checking and start assuming, and "I know what you meant" can do a lot of quiet damage in a long relationship. Children are often labelled early as the difficult one or the easy one, and the label becomes a lens that only sees what fits. With ADHD, attention is pulled by whatever is new or urgent and can lock on hard, so someone may truly not have seen or heard. It helps to get their attention first and to put requests in writing. More in the full chapter.

Common mix-ups

- **"I just see things as they are."** Everyone sees through a lens, and knowing that is where fairness starts.
- **"My memory is a recording."** Memory is rebuilt each time, so two honest people can remember the same event differently.
- **"Giving the benefit of the doubt means ignoring what happened."** It means checking the story before deciding, and if something hurtful keeps happening, that matters.
- **"Their face or tone told me what they meant."** Faces and tones vary a lot between people, cultures and neurotypes, so treat them as clues.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Start with how they feel.** Make sense of the feeling first, and only then ask gently whether there is another way to see it.

- **Offer information.** “I know she had a hard week” helps more than “You’re being unfair to her.”
- **Check your own guesses out loud**, as in “I assumed he was annoyed. I’ll ask.”
- **Be careful with labels.** Labels for children, coworkers or family members stick, and then shape what everyone sees.
- **Believe people about their own experience.** Seeing other angles never means telling someone their experience didn’t happen.

> WORDS TO TRY
> “That sounds really hurtful. Do you know what was going on for them?” “It might be worth asking. Want to plan what to say?”

When to get more help

Seeing other people’s side is a strength. It should never mean doubting yourself when you know something is wrong. If someone often tells you that what you saw, heard or remember didn’t happen, that you’re “too sensitive” or “imagining it,” and you find yourself unsure of your own mind, take that seriously. It can be part of controlling behaviour. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) and Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) can help, privately.

It may also help to talk to a counsellor or other trained professional if you notice you often feel others are against you, find it hard to trust anyone, or keep getting stuck in the same painful stories about yourself. Those patterns are common, understandable and often change with support.

This chapter is general education, not diagnosis or therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Rewind the talk: see their side: a free perspective-taking tool.
- Chat analyzer: how a sentence might land before you say it.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

TOOL
Chat analyzer
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

More for your situation

- Book 1, Chapter 1: where your lens came from (page 9)
- Book 4, Chapter 3: full tanks and different angles (page 51)
- Family rifts, Co-parenting and For grown-up children
- Communication between different minds
- For teens and For parents
- The whole book · Help by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

ONLINE
For grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children

ONLINE
Communication between different minds
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
For parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents

ONLINE
The whole book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from
Where your lens came from
Know Yourself Kindly, page 9

Book 4, Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees
Why the other person doesn't see the work
Share the Load, page 9

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
Seven angles on the same moment
Share the Load, page 51

Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture
Us and them, and the stories groups tell
page 97

PUT IT TO USE

Rewind the talk: see their side
A free perspective-taking tool
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

Chat analyzer
How a sentence might land before you say it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing-in-depth

4

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 4

Attachment, trust and belonging

Why we need each other, how the bonds we had early on shape what we expect today, and how trust and belonging are built, lost and rebuilt, one small moment at a time.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Belonging is a basic need
2. Early bonds teach us what to expect
3. Patterns, not boxes
4. Trust is built in small moments
5. Feeling safe with someone calms the body
6. Fitting in isn't the same as belonging
7. When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time
8. You can start building connection from wherever you are
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Two tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **One owner per job** (Book 4, Chapter 2 (page 27)) works because trust is built from small promises kept, and a named owner turns a vague hope that someone will do it into a promise others can rely on.
- **The monthly look-back** (Book 4, Chapter 5 (page 93)) looks at the month and leaves both people out of the dock,

because feeling safe is what lets people say what went wrong without bracing for blame.

SUNDAY, 9:30PM

Kai sent a long message to a friend at lunchtime, and it has been read without a reply. By evening Kai has gone from thinking she is busy to thinking she is annoyed to wondering whether anybody really likes him. The friend, meanwhile, is at her nephew's birthday party with her phone in her coat pocket.

01

Belonging is a basic need.

People need to feel connected, the way we need food and sleep. When we feel left out, it can hurt in a way that feels almost physical (Naomi Eisenberger and colleagues, 2003). That hurt works like hunger, telling us to reach for connection.

For example, Rhea moves to a new city for work. She is busy and doing well, yet by the third month she feels flat and teary on Sundays, when the office is shut and nobody in the city knows her well enough to call.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Feeling lonely says I need connection, like anyone does."

TRY THIS.

This week, reach out to one person, even if it is only a short "thinking of you" message.

02

Early bonds teach us what to expect.

As children, we learn from the people who cared for us whether others will come when we need them. If help usually came, we tend to expect it. If it came sometimes, or rarely, we may learn to cling harder or to stop asking. These lessons are a starting point that later relationships can change. This is the idea of attachment, first described by John Bowlby (1969) and studied by Mary Ainsworth and colleagues (1978).

A toddler at the park runs off to explore, runs back to check that his grandmother is still on the bench, and runs off again, braver each time because he knows where she is.

YOU COULD SAY

(to a child) "I'm right here. Go and look, and come back whenever you want."

THIS WEEK.

Think of one person who was a safe base for you, at any age, and what they did that helped.

03

Patterns, not boxes.

As adults, some of us worry a lot about being left, and reach out more when we feel unsure. Some of us pull back when things get close, and need more space. Many of us feel mostly secure, and most of us mix all three.

These are patterns that can soften and change, especially in steady, kind relationships. Cindy Hazan and Phillip Shaver (1987) first described them in adults, and later work, such as R. Chris Fraley and colleagues (2015), suggests they work as sliding scales.

For example, when things feel tense, Ronan wants to talk it through straight away while his wife Clara needs to go quiet first. He reads her quiet as a sign she is leaving, and she reads his questions as pressure. Once they see the pattern, they agree that Clara will say "I need an hour, and I'm coming back," and that Ronan will wait.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I'm not going anywhere. I just need some quiet. Let's talk at eight."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Notice whether you reach out more or pull back when you feel unsure of someone, and leave judgement out of it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Our pause plan

Imani and Kwame, married ten years

Our pause plan

Fill this in together on a calm day, or fill it in yourself and send it to your partner to change.

Our pause word or sentence
"Pause. I'll be back at ...", with a hand on the heart

Shortest break, so our bodies can settle
30 minutes

Whoever pauses names a clock time to come back, no later than
the same evening

If one of us can't come back on time
Send one text with a new time. No silence.

The first sentence when we come back

"I'm back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?"

YOUR PLAN, READY TO SEND

Our pause plan

Pause word: "Pause. I'll be back at …", with a hand on the heart

Shortest break: 30 minutes

Return time: whoever pauses names a clock time, no later than the same evening

If one of us can't come back on time: Send one text with a new time. No silence.

When we come back, we start with: "I'm back. You first: what do you most want me to hear?"

For relationships where everyone feels safe.

Fill in your own: Our pause plan

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE

Our pause plan

spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

04

Trust is built in small moments.

Trust rarely comes from big gestures. It grows from small, ordinary things done again and again, such as doing what you said, turning towards someone when they reach out, and being the same person on a hard day as on a good one.

A new team member says she will send the figures by Thursday, and she does. The next week she warns early that something will be late. By the third month her manager trusts her completely, and he would struggle to name a single moment when it happened.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I said I'd do it by Friday. I'm running late, so here's where it's at."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Keep one small promise today, and notice how it feels to be someone who does what they said.

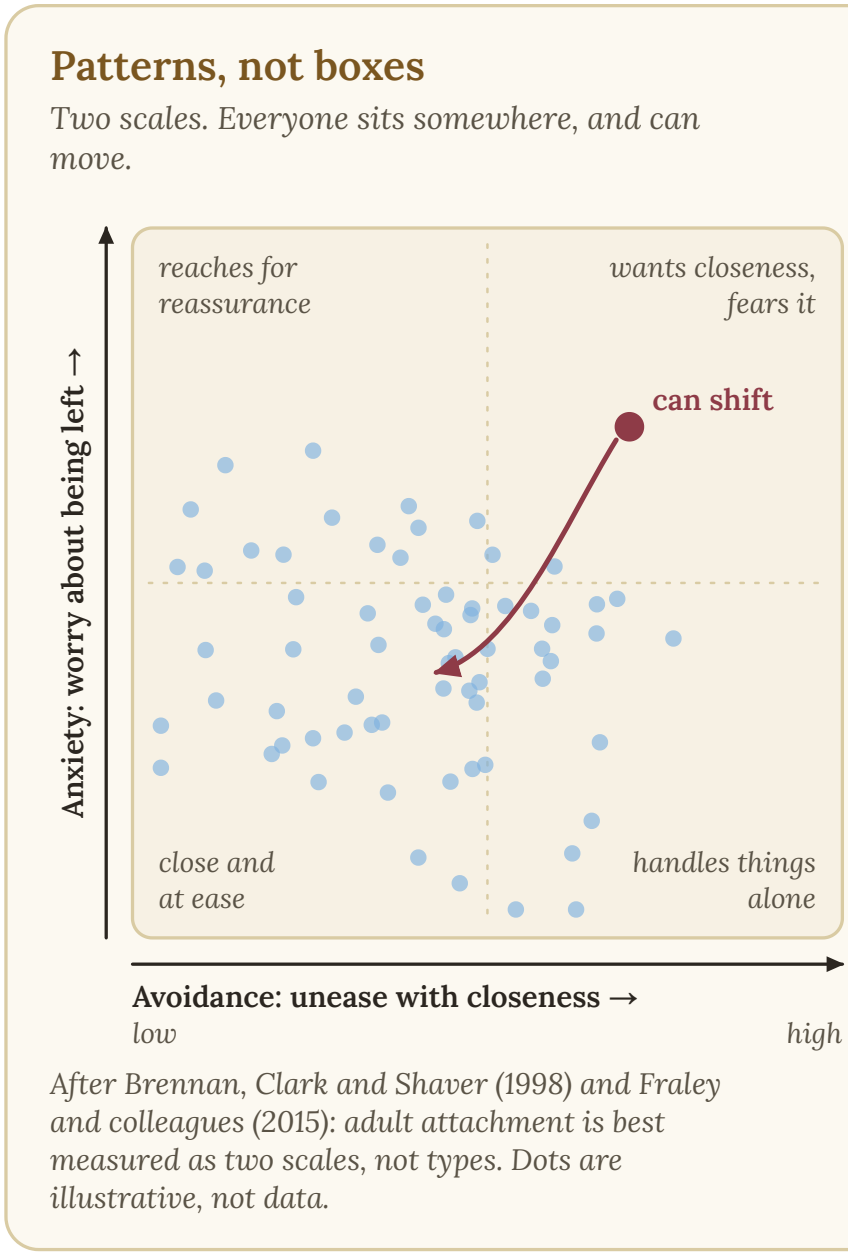


FIGURE 6 Attachment as two scales, not four boxes: worry about being left, and unease with closeness. Everyone sits somewhere, and can move. Dots are illustrative.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Trust grows in small moments that repeat. This workpaper helps you notice the little rituals you already have, and keep them going.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-15 · free to print
Keep your little rituals alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

05

Feeling safe with someone calms the body.

Being with someone we trust can settle our nervous system. In one study, holding a trusted partner's hand calmed the brain's response to threat (James Coan and colleagues, 2006). A calm voice, a hand to hold, or just someone nearby can make a hard moment easier to bear. It works both ways, so we can be that safe presence for others too, often without saying much.

For example, after a panic attack, Kieran's friend doesn't try to fix anything. He sits next to him on the step outside the flats and says, "Take your time. I'm here," and they stay there until Kieran's breathing slows.

WORDS TO TRY

"You don't have to talk. I'll just sit with you." "Would company help right now, or quiet?"

TRY THIS.

Notice who helps you feel calmer, and tell them simply that you always feel better after seeing them.

06

Fitting in isn't the same as belonging.

Fitting in means changing yourself to be accepted. Belonging means being accepted as you are. Groups like teams, families, clubs and communities can offer both. Being left out of a group hurts even when the group doesn't matter much to us, and real belonging grows where people feel safe to be themselves and to speak up.

At a new job, Ola laughs at jokes she doesn't find funny and hides the fact that she doesn't drink, and she goes home exhausted every Friday. At her book club she says what she really thinks, and people ask her to say more.

YOU COULD SAY

(in a group) "I see it a bit differently. Is it okay if I say why?" "Has everyone had a chance to say something?"

THIS WEEK.

Think of one place where you can be fully yourself, and how you might spend a little more time there.

07

When trust breaks, rebuilding takes time.

When someone lets us down badly, trust doesn't come back with one apology. It returns slowly, as words are matched by actions over time. The person who broke trust can own what happened and be patient. The person who was hurt can decide, at their own pace, whether and how much to trust again.

For example, two adult sisters fall out after one shares a private story at a family dinner. The apology is a start, and what slowly rebuilds trust is the months afterwards, when the story never comes up again and the sister checks before sharing anything.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I know sorry isn't enough. I'll show you, and you can take whatever time you need."

ONE SMALL STEP.

If you've broken someone's trust, name one specific thing you'll do differently, and do it.

08

You can start building connection from wherever you are.

If you feel alone right now, big friendships can feel out of reach, and belonging can start much smaller, with a chat with a neighbour, a regular class or an online group about something you love. Even small, light contact with people we barely know can lift our mood (Gillian Sandstrom and Elizabeth Dunn, 2014).

After his divorce, Martin starts saying more than "thanks" to the man at the coffee stall, and a few weeks later they talk football every morning. It is a small friendship, and it makes Mondays easier.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I'm new around here. Is there anything you'd recommend?" "I loved what you said in the group. Would you like to get a coffee sometime?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Have one small, friendly exchange with someone you don't know well this week.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: one small hello is a great start! Want an idea? There's a tool that picks one for you.

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Stay close: one small idea
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

MONDAY, 8:10AM

Kai's phone buzzes with an apology. Her phone was in her coat all day at her nephew's party, she loved the message, and is he free for coffee on Thursday? Kai thinks about how far last night's story ran, and decides that next time a reply is slow he will send a light "No rush, just thinking of you" and leave it there.

If you're a teenager

Ezra is sixteen when he sees a photo of his three closest friends at the cinema and finds out there is a group chat he isn't in. It hurts like a punch, because being left out really does register a bit like pain. He drafts something sharp, deletes it and messages one

friend instead, saying he's a bit gutted not to be asked and asking whether he did something. It turns out they thought he would be at football. One of the friendships really is drifting, though, and that is allowed to hurt too.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Bit gutted not to be asked. Did something happen?" "I'd like to come next time, even if I can't always make it." "I miss how we used to be. Are we okay?"

In everyday life

When one partner texts a lot while apart and the other forgets, agreeing on one goodnight message can keep both feeling connected. A child who acts up at pick-up may simply be letting go of a long day with the safest person they know. A friend who always cancels may be overwhelmed, and "Is it easier if we do something short?" keeps the door open. At work, a team where mistakes can be admitted without blame builds trust faster than one where everyone hides them, and in a shared house, one simple weekly meal can turn people who share a kitchen into people who look out for each other.

On your own: belonging with yourself

Belonging also includes how you treat yourself. If you are kind to yourself on a bad day, you carry a small safe base wherever you go, and people who learn to comfort themselves often find it easier to let others in, because they are less afraid of being let down. You are allowed to need people, and a lonely day is hard without being a forecast. On my own has more for people living alone.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

- **"Needing people means I'm needy."** Everyone needs connection, including the people who hide it well.
- **"My attachment style is fixed for life."** Patterns can change, especially through steady, kind relationships and reflection.
- **"Jealousy and checking up show how much they love me."** Reaching for reassurance is human, and so is asking for something out of care for the relationship. Controlling who someone sees, or checking their phone without agreement, is not love and is not an attachment style. See signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety).
- **"If I forgive, I have to trust again straight away."** Forgiving and trusting are different. Trust can return slowly, or not at all, and that's your call.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Be a steady presence.** Reliability matters more than big gestures. Turn up when you said you would.
- **Take loneliness seriously.** If someone says they feel alone, listen before you remind them how many friends they have.
- **Invite, and keep inviting.** People who feel left out may say no a few times, and a warm invitation with no pressure still matters.
- **Make room in groups** by noticing who is on the edge and asking their view.
- **Leave labels out.** Telling someone they are "so avoidant" or "so clingy" rarely helps, while asking what would help often does.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm here, and I'm not going anywhere." "We're having a few people over on Friday. No pressure, but I'd love you to come."

When to get more help

- **If loneliness has lasted a long time,** or comes with low mood, hopelessness or thoughts of not wanting to be here, please talk to a doctor or a mental health service. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number or see Upset right now.
- **If fear of being left, or of getting close, keeps hurting your relationships,** a counsellor or therapist can help you understand where it comes from and how to change it.
- **If someone uses your need for them against you,** by cutting you off from friends, checking where you are, or threatening to leave to get their way, that is not about attachment. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

- **If trust was broken in a way that frightened you,** you don't owe anyone a second chance. Your safety comes first.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Reading on the website

Pick one small way to turn towards someone this week. Turning towards, When one talks and one goes quiet and How to apologise so it counts have more ideas.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Turning towards
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward

TOOL
Cool-down corner: make a pause plan
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

ONLINE
How to apologise so it counts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

More for your situation

- On my own after a breakup
- Friends
- Parents and foster, adoptive and kinship families
- Long distance

- Family rifts
- Coming out as an adult
- At work
- Grief and later life
- Find it by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own after a breakup
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
Parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents

ONLINE
foster, adoptive and kinship families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship

ONLINE
Long distance
spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
Coming out as an adult
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Find it by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Belonging is a basic need.** Feeling lonely or left out is a signal, like hunger.
- ✓ **Early bonds set expectations that can change.** What we learned about being cared for can soften over time.
- ✓ **Trust grows in small moments.** Doing what you said, again and again, matters more than big gestures.
- ✓ **You can start small**, with one friendly exchange or one kept promise.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from — Know Yourself Kindly, page 9
Early trust and the rules from home

Chapter 5 · Closeness and love — page 81
Being known, at every age

Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture — page 97
Belonging to groups, and their pull

Book 2, Chapter 4 · Loss, grief and big life changes — Heal and Steady, page 73
When a bond is lost

PUT IT TO USE



Bonding: how closeness grows

What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family, coworkers and you

`spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding`



Friends

When a friendship drifts, and how to reach out

`spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends`



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-5-belonging-in-depth`

5

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 5

Closeness and love: being known, at every age

How closeness grows, what it means to feel truly known, how love changes over the years, and how it looks in every kind of relationship, at every age, including for people on their own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Love comes in many forms
2. Closeness grows from being known
3. Closeness is built a step at a time
4. Feeling understood matters most
5. Old maps show up in love
6. Love changes over time
7. Love at every age
8. Love is something you do
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation

FRIDAY, 10:30PM

You and Charlie have shared a home for eleven years. Tonight you are both on the sofa and both on your phones, and you realise you can't remember the last time you talked about anything except bills, the boiler and whose turn it is to cook. You love Charlie, and you feel oddly alone in the same room.

This chapter is about closeness in all its forms, far beyond romance. It looks at what helps people feel near to each other, why

closeness can fade and how it can grow again, and it builds on Chapter 4 (page 63), on attachment and trust.

01

Love comes in many forms.

The ancient Greeks had several words for love, for friends, for family, for romantic partners and for strangers. People love in many ways today too. There are lifelong friendships, partners of any gender, people with more than one partner, chosen family, people who are asexual or aromantic and build deep closeness without romance or sex, and people on their own who pour love into friends, family, pets, work and community. A life can be full of love without a partner in it. A woman in her fifties who has never wanted a partner describes her best friend of thirty years as her great love story. They have been through two house moves, one cancer scare and more Sunday phone calls than either could count.

It can help to write down three or more people you love, of any kind, and next to each one way you show it.

02

Closeness grows from being known.

Intimacy is about much more than touch or romance, and at its heart is being known. The psychologists Reis and Shaver described it as a back-and-forth, in which one person shares something real about themselves and the other responds in a way that leaves them feeling understood, accepted and cared for. In a diary study by Laurenceau, Barrett and Pietromonaco (1998), feeling that the other person really responded was a big part of what made everyday conversations feel intimate.

Two brothers who mostly talk about football are driving to their dad's care home when one admits that he finds the visits really

hard. The other says he does too, and that he always feels guilty on the way home. It is the longest conversation they have had in years, and it lasts until the car park. Sharing one small, true thing with someone you care about, a worry, a hope or something that made you happy this week, and noticing how they respond, is the same process on a smaller scale.

03

Closeness is built a step at a time.

People usually get close by sharing a little more, and then a little more, when it feels safe. In a well-known study by Aron and colleagues (1997), pairs of strangers who took turns asking gradually more personal questions, now known as the "36 questions", felt closer after forty-five minutes than pairs who made small talk. The same idea works in friendships and long relationships, where closeness grows when both people take small, matched steps. Two new neighbours start with the weather and the parking. A few months later one asks how the other's mum is doing, and some time after that one of them says, "Can I tell you what's really been going on?"

Next time you talk to someone you would like to know better, ask one question a little deeper than usual, such as what has been on their mind lately, and if they answer, share something of your own back.

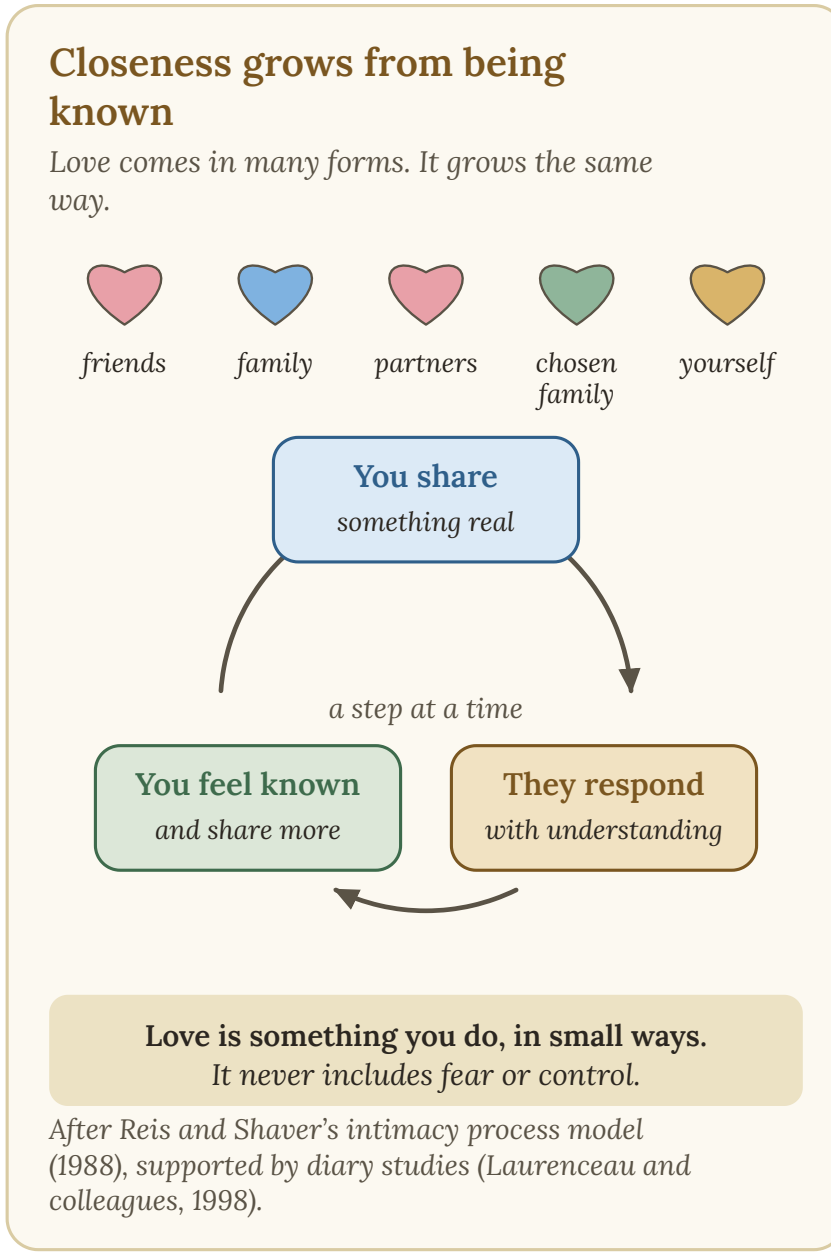


FIGURE 7 Closeness grows from being known: you share something real, the other person responds with understanding, and you share a little more.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Closeness grows when you know what feels like care to the other person, not just to you. A “What feels like care” card is a gentle way to find out.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
How you connect: what feels like care
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

04

Feeling understood matters most.

What makes someone feel loved is often less about grand gestures and more about feeling understood. Researchers call this *responsiveness*, meaning noticing, understanding and caring about what matters to the other person, and it shows in small moments such as how you react to good news. Gable and colleagues (2004) found that people whose partners usually met their good news with real interest and warmth felt closer and more satisfied together. When a teenager announces that she has been picked for the band, her grandad stops what he is doing, smiles and asks which instrument and when the first concert is, and she talks for twenty minutes.

The next time someone shares good news with you, put your phone down and ask two follow-up questions.

05

Old maps show up in love.

The patterns from Chapter 4 (page 63) often come out most strongly with the people we love most. Hazan and Shaver (1987) suggested that adult love uses the same attachment system as childhood bonds. When closeness feels shaky, some people reach harder for reassurance and others pull back to feel safe, and both are ways of protecting something precious. When his partner goes quiet, Leo texts five times in an hour, while his partner, who goes quiet in order to calm down, feels crowded. They agree that his partner will say, "I need an hour, and I'll message you at eight," and Leo finds he can wait for a known time.

Notice what you do when closeness feels shaky, and tell someone you trust what helps you feel safe again.

06

Love changes over time.

Early love is often intense, with racing thoughts and a lot of longing, and over the years it usually settles into something calmer and deeper. A review by Acevedo and Aron (2009) found that some people in long relationships still report strong romantic love, without the anxious, obsessive edge of early love, and that this was linked to being happier together.

In experiments by Aron and colleagues (2000), couples who tried a new, mildly challenging activity together felt better about their relationship afterwards than couples given a dull task. After twenty-five years, one couple sign up for a pottery class. They are both terrible at it, laugh all evening and bring home a bowl that won't stand up, and on the way home one of them says it felt like a date. Something new for both of you matters more than something big, whether that is a new walk, a new recipe or a new place.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: little rituals, like a Sunday walk or a goodnight text, keep love warm through the years. Look after the ones you have.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-15 · free to print
Keep your little rituals alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

07

Love at every age.

Love looks different across a life. Teenagers' first loves can be huge and real, and adults juggle love with work, children and caring for parents. Many older people choose to spend their time with fewer, closer people, which Carstensen and colleagues (1999) linked to feeling that time is more limited, so that the most meaningful relationships matter more. People find new love at seventy and eighty, and people lose great loves and carry them always. A widower of seventy-eight meets a woman at his walking group, and when his children are surprised he tells them, "I loved your mother for fifty years. I still do. And I'm allowed to be happy now."

If it feels right, ask someone from another generation, an older relative or a younger neighbour, about love in their life.

08

Love is something you do.

Feelings of love come and go, while the actions of love can be steady. They include turning towards someone when they speak, keeping small promises, saying thank you and sorry, and making room for who they are. Physical closeness, like a hug or holding hands, matters a lot to some people and less to others, and sex is part of closeness in some relationships and not in others. What matters is that both people feel comfortable and free to say yes or no. Love never includes fear, threats or control.

A woman notices that her friend has been quiet since his divorce. She never says she loves him, but every Thursday she texts the single word “Walk?” and turns up at his door. You might ask someone you love what small thing makes them feel cared for, and then do it this week.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Our time-together deal

Jamal and Tess, a couple; Jamal games most evenings

Our time-together deal

Your name
Jamal

Their name
Tess

Game nights (or long phone time)
Tuesday and Friday evenings, plus Sunday afternoon

Heads-up rule
Say before a session over an hour, and roughly when it ends.

When one of us asks for time
Finish this match, then I’m yours. No new one.

Our protected evening
Wednesday, from 7: we cook together

Phone-free times
Dinner, and the first 20 minutes in bed

Chores before the session
Dishes and our own jobs for the day are done first.

YOUR DEAL, READY TO SEND

Our time-together deal (Jamal and Tess), with each line above. A link holds the deal as it is right now: if either of you changes something, send a new link.

Fill in your own: Our time-together deal

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Our time-together deal
spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can share a little of yourself, listen well, turn towards the people you love and keep small promises. You can't make someone love you, or love you in the way you want. If closeness keeps hurting you, or you feel afraid, that is not a failure of love on your part. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

THE NEXT FRIDAY, 10:30PM

This time you leave both phones in the kitchen, make two cups of tea and ask Charlie what they have been thinking about lately that they haven't told you. Charlie is quiet for a moment and then talks about their dad getting older, and how they dread the phone ringing late at night. You listen, and then you talk about the restructure at work. The tea goes cold, and it is midnight before either of you looks at the clock.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

If you're a teenager

First love can be huge and real, and so can a first breakup. Ines is sixteen when she is dumped by message on a Tuesday night, and she cries until two in the morning. Being told by adults that she will get over it doesn't help. Telling her cousin, who simply listens, does, along with muting the chat instead of rereading it and a rule of no checking his profile after ten. A few weeks later she notices that a whole day has gone by without her thinking about him.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't need advice, I just need to tell someone." "Can we reply when we can, rather than all day?" And if you are the one ending it, "I don't want to go out any more. I'm sorry. It isn't about something you did wrong."

In everyday life

On your own

Being single, widowed, divorced or happily alone doesn't mean a life without love, because friendships, family, community and the way you treat yourself are all places where love lives. If you want a partner and don't have one, that longing is real and worth being gentle with (see On my own). Most partners drift into talking only about jobs and bills, and one real question a week can bring them back. Friendship needs tending like any other love, and families often love each other deeply and say it rarely, so a short "I'm glad you're my sister" can mean a great deal.

- **Different levels of desire.** This is very common in long relationships and is nobody's fault. Talk at a calm time, keep some affection that doesn't have to lead anywhere, and remember that a kind "no" is a no to the moment and never a rejection of the person. A qualified sex therapist or couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

- **"If the spark fades, love is over."** Early intensity usually settles, and many long relationships stay warm, close and lively.
- **"If they loved me, they'd just know what I need."** Nobody reads minds, and saying what helps is a gift.
- **"Jealousy proves love."** Feeling jealous is human, and asking for something out of care for the relationship is not control. Checking up without agreement, cutting someone off or punishing them is not love. See signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

If you want to help someone else with this

Respect their kind of love, without assuming that everyone wants a partner, children or one kind of relationship. Be a safe person to tell things to, which means listening without judging and keeping what they share private. After a loss or a breakup, keep showing up, because many people get plenty of support for two weeks and very little after that.

- **If you're worried about someone's relationship,** stay close and kind rather than criticising their partner. If they seem afraid, gently share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm always glad to hear from you." "You don't have to explain your relationship to me. I just want you to be happy and safe."

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

When to get more help

- If you feel very lonely or low most days for two weeks or more, talk to a doctor or counsellor.
- If closeness feels frightening, or you keep ending up in relationships that hurt you, a counsellor or therapist can help you understand why.

- Couples, family or relationship counselling can help when you feel stuck, distant or keep having the same fight.
- If someone you love controls you, frightens you, checks your phone, cuts you off from friends or pressures you into anything you don't want, that isn't love. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.
- If you're in danger now, call your local emergency number. Upset right now? can help you take the first step.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Reading on the website

More for your situation

- Attachment, trust and belonging (Chapter 4, page 63)
- Friends · More than two · Long distance
- Coming out as an adult
- On my own · Grief and later life
- Retired together · Empty nest
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
More than two
spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two

ONLINE
Long distance
spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance

ONLINE
Coming out as an adult
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Retired together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together

ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Love comes in many forms.
- ✓ Closeness is built a step at a time.
- ✓ Old maps show up in love.
- ✓ Love changes over time.
- ✓ Love is something you do.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging
Attachment and trust
page 63

Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune
Staying in tune day to day page 9

Book 4, Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees
Noticing the work love does Share the Load, page 9

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming
Growing as a person inside a relationship Know Yourself Kindly, page 45

PUT IT TO USE

Bonding: how closeness grows
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

Turning towards
On small daily moments of connection
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-15-love-in-depth

6

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 6

Fitting in: groups, influence and culture

Why fitting in pulls so hard, how groups shape what we say and do, how culture and family set the unwritten rules, and how to stay yourself, and disagree kindly, without losing your place, whether the group is a family, a friendship, a team, a faith, a neighbourhood or a group chat.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. The pull to fit in is old and strong
2. We go along more than we think
3. Authority can lead people a long way
4. "Us and them" forms fast
5. Norms are the rules nobody wrote down
6. Cultures differ, and so do people inside them
7. Every family is a small culture
8. Online groups pull harder and faster
9. You can belong and still be yourself
10. Disagree kindly, and early
11. If you're a teenager
12. In everyday life
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Reading on this site
16. More for your situation

THURSDAY, 9:20PM

The family group chat is buzzing. Someone has posted a joke about your cousin's new partner, and the laughing faces are piling up underneath it. You don't find it funny, and you also don't want to be the one who can't take a joke. Everyone else seems fine with it, and your thumb is already hovering over the laughing face.

We all belong to groups, and we need them. Chapter 4 (page 63) looks at belonging, at why we need each other and how trust grows. This chapter looks at the other side, at how groups pull on us, why we go along and how to stay true to yourself while staying connected.

01

The pull to fit in is old and strong.

For most of human history, being part of a group meant survival, and being left out still feels alarming. In studies by Williams and colleagues (2000), people who were simply left out of an online ball-throwing game, by strangers they would never meet, felt worse and less as if they belonged. So we bend to stay in, by laughing at jokes, keeping quiet and going along. A new starter at a warehouse laughs at a teasing nickname he dislikes, because more than anything that first month he wants to be one of the team.

This week, notice one moment when you went along with something to fit in. Wanting to fit in is normal, and you still get to choose what you go along with.

02

We go along more than we think.

In Solomon Asch's famous experiments (Asch, 1956), people judged which of three lines matched another line. When the actors around them all gave the same wrong answer, people went along with the group on about a third of the answers, even though the right answer was obvious.

Many people never went along at all. Later research, such as a review by Bond and Smith (1996), found the effect is real but varies, smaller in more recent studies and larger in cultures that put the group first. In a meeting where everyone praises a plan, one woman sees a big problem and stays quiet, and afterwards two

colleagues tell her they had doubts too. Writing down your own view before a group decision, and only then listening to the group, makes it easier to say what you actually think.

03

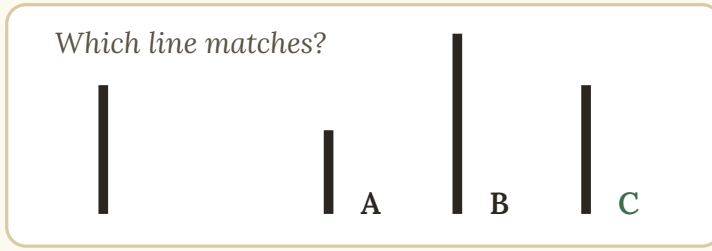
Authority can lead people a long way.

In Stanley Milgram's experiments (Milgram, 1963), many ordinary people kept giving what they believed were painful electric shocks to a stranger because a man in a lab coat told them to, although no shocks were real. Burger (2009) repeated part of the study safely and found similar results. The studies are also debated. Later researchers, such as Haslam and Reicher (2012), argue that people went along when they believed in the cause, and many people refused.

A nurse is told by a senior doctor to give a dose that looks wrong to her. She checks, speaks up and turns out to be right, and checking was the loyal thing to do. Think of one person whose word you tend to follow without question, and whether there is anything you would want to check next time, perhaps with "Before I do this, can I check one thing?"

We go along more than we think

And one other voice changes a lot.



Alone against the group



went along on about 1 in 3 answers

With one ally



going along fell sharply

One calm, kind voice saying "I see it differently" often frees others to say so too.

Asch (1956). About a quarter of people never went along. Across 133 later studies the effect held but varied by time and culture (Bond and Smith, 1996).

FIGURE 8 We go along more than we think, and one other voice changes a lot. In Asch's studies, going along fell sharply when one other person gave the right answer.

04

“Us and them” forms fast.

Part of how we see ourselves comes from our groups, whether that is a family, a town, a team, a faith or a job. Tajfel and Turner (1979) called this social identity. It brings pride and loyalty, and it also makes us quick to favour “us” and to see “them” as all the same, even when the groups are formed on almost nothing. Two branches of one family always sit apart at weddings, and nobody can quite remember why. One year a cousin quietly swaps the seating plan, and the two sides discover a shared weakness for terrible music.

Think of a “them” in your life and name one person from that group as an individual, with something they like and something they worry about.

05

Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.

Every group has norms about what you wear, how you speak, what you laugh at and what you never mention, and we often guess them wrong. In studies at one university, Prentice and Miller (1993) found that most students were privately less comfortable with heavy drinking than they thought everyone else was. Each person thought they were the odd one out, so everyone kept going along. In one office everyone answers emails at midnight because they think it is expected, until a manager says she doesn’t expect replies after six, and the relief is almost audible.

Pick one unwritten rule in a group you belong to and ask one person, privately, what they really think of it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

House rules for us

Shona and her son Dexter, 15

House rules for us

Person A
Shona

Person B
Dexter

Date of this list
3 October 2026

Our rules, and who keeps each one

Rule	Who keeps it	Why it matters to Shona	Why it matters to Dexter
Phones charge in the kitchen from 10 on school nights	*Both (decide together)*	*I sleep better knowing you're not up at 2*	*Fine if it's both our phones, not just mine*
Homework before games, Monday to Thursday	*Dexter*	*Less nagging from me*	*Weekends are mine, then*
Say where you're going and when you'll be back	*Both (decide together)*	*So I don't worry*	*Mum does it too, so it's fair*
Friday tea together, no phones at the table	*Both (decide together)*	*It's my favourite hour of the week*	*Only if I can pick the food sometimes*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Rules with someone who keeps them

4 of 4. Every rule has someone who keeps it.

Changes to the list

Date	What changed	Who
3 Oct 2026	*Dexter asked for weekends without phone rules. Agreed for a month, then we look again.*	*Shona and Dexter*

The norms nobody wrote down, written down, with room for both of them to change them.

Fill in your own: House rules for us

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

06

Cultures differ, and so do people inside them.

Cultures differ in how much they put the individual or the group first, which researchers call individualism and collectivism (Hofstede, 1980). In some, standing out is admired, and in others fitting in and keeping harmony are signs of maturity. Labels need care, though. A large review by Oyserman and colleagues (2002) found the differences were smaller and less tidy than often claimed, and individuals vary hugely within every culture. A woman raised in a close-knit family moves in with a partner who grew up being told to do his own thing. He sees her daily calls home as clingy and she sees his rare calls as cold, while each is following the rules they learned.

Name one thing you think of as simply how people should behave, then ask where you learned it and whether someone else might have learned the opposite.

07

Every family is a small culture.

Families have their own norms about how loud people are, how feelings are shown, who does what, what is talked about and what isn't, and how you say sorry, if you do. We often only notice our family's rules when we live with someone from a different family, and Where your lens came from (Book 1, Chapter 1, page 9) looks at the rules you grew up with. Two housemates clash over the kitchen because in one's family you wash up straight away and in the other's you wash up in the morning, and neither of them is lazy or fussy.

Write down three rules from the family you grew up in. Keep one you value, and question one you don't, perhaps by asking, "What did yours do? Shall we make our own rule?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Kitchen-table check-in: family plan
Amaka and Chris, new parents, with Chris's parents

Our family plan

A plan for the family, not a list of chores.

Who's in this plan (optional)
Amaka, Chris, Nana Joy and Grandad Pete

Visits
Sunday lunch every other week, 12 to 3. Text the day before.

Advice
Ask first: "Do you want ideas, or just to talk?"

The baby's or children's routines
Nap at 1. Back to sleep on her back, always. Ask us before any new food.

A regular job for a grandparent or relative
Grandad Pete does the Tuesday morning walk with the pram.

We'll look at this again on
The first Sunday of December

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side.

Two family cultures, one plan written on purpose.
Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: family plan

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Kitchen-table check-in
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/check-ins

08

Online groups pull harder and faster.

Group chats, forums and social media make group pressure quicker and more public, because likes and replies show the norm instantly. In a study of over half a million posts, Brady and colleagues (2017) found that messages with more moral and emotional words spread further, mostly among people who already agreed. Outrage travels fast while quiet doubts stay put. A parents' group chat turns against a teacher after one angry post, and a dad who knows the teacher well sends a calm message saying he would

want to hear her side before anyone decides. Two other parents agree with him, and the thread goes quiet.

Before you react to a heated post, wait ten minutes, then decide whether to reply, to reply privately or to leave it.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: group chats move fast! Before you send a reply, a helper can read the room with you.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Chat analyzer
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/signal-translator

09

You can belong and still be yourself.

Belonging means being accepted as you are, while fitting in means changing in order to be accepted (Chapter 4 (page 63) says more). Good groups have room for difference. It helps to know your own values, to have more than one group and to have at least one ally, and in Asch's experiments, when just one other person gave the right answer, going along with the group dropped sharply. A teenager who loves chess is teased about it by his friends, so he joins a chess club as well as keeping his friends, and with two groups neither one gets to decide who he is.

Write down three things you value, and the next time a group pulls on you, check whether the pull is in line with them.

10

Disagree kindly, and early.

You don't have to choose between going along and starting a war. A kind disagreement is short and calm, it is about the issue rather than the people, and it leaves room for others. Speaking early is easier than speaking late, and a private word often works better than speaking in front of everyone. Some people keep a sentence ready, such as "I see it a bit differently. Can I say why?", "I'm not comfortable with that joke" or "Can we hear from people who haven't spoken yet?"

Choose the sentence that sounds most like you and say it out loud a few times, so it is ready when you need it.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Disagreeing early and kindly is easier with the words ready. This workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-09 · free to print
Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can notice the pull to fit in, check what you actually think, choose your groups, and say "I see it differently" kindly.

You can't control what a group does, and you don't have to stay in a group that keeps asking you to hide who you are or go against what's right. If a group, a family or a partner uses pressure, fear or threats to control you, that's not belonging. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

THURSDAY, 9:40PM

You delete the laughing face and message your aunt privately instead. "I know it was meant to be funny, but it might hurt if they see it. Could we leave it?" A few minutes later the joke disappears, followed by a message to you saying it was only a bit of fun and people are too sensitive these days. Later your cousin messages you to say thank you, because she saw it before it went. Your aunt is noticeably short with you at Sunday lunch, and you still don't know whether that will pass.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

If you're a teenager

Group chats are where a lot of friendship happens, and a lot of hurt. Rhys is fifteen when he finds a photo of himself from PE being joked about in his class chat. He doesn't answer back.

He screenshots it, mutes the chat and tells his sister, and together they tell his form tutor. Then a girl in his class messages him privately to say it wasn't funny and that she is sorry she didn't say anything. Most people in a group chat don't like what is happening, and each of them thinks everyone else does.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm not okay with this. Please delete it." To a friend, "That wasn't okay. Are you alright?" To an adult, "Something's happening online and I need help with it."

In everyday life

Having no group can be as hard as having a pushy one, and groups built around something you enjoy bring belonging along with the activity. Partners bring two families and two sets of rules, which are worth talking about openly before you make your own. Children and teenagers feel peer pressure strongly, and practising a "no" that saves face helps them. Old family roles, such as the joker, the peacekeeper or the black sheep, can be hard to step out of. At work, when everyone agrees too fast, it helps if whoever leads shares their view last and asks each person to name one risk before deciding (more in the full chapter). And online, you are allowed to mute, leave or take a break from groups that leave you feeling worse.

If you want to help someone else with this

If someone speaks up, back them up, even quietly with "I think that's a fair point," because one ally makes a big difference. In any group you lead, invite quieter people and different views by asking what nobody has thought of yet. If someone seems to be going along against their wishes, ask gently, away from the group, and keep an eye on who gets left out of chats, plans and jokes, so you can bring them in.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I noticed you went quiet when they said that. Are you okay?"
> "I'd like to hear what you think, even if it's different."

When to get more help

Group pressure is part of life. It may be time for more help if:

- a group, family or partner controls who you see, what you wear, what you spend or what you believe, or punishes you for disagreeing;
- you feel you can't leave a group without being threatened, shamed or cut off from everyone you know;
- you're being bullied, at school, at work or online;
- being left out or pressured is leaving you very low, anxious or hopeless.

Talk to someone you trust, a counsellor or a doctor. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help if someone at home controls or frightens you. For low mood or worry, see Book 2, Chapter 3 (page 51). If you are thinking about ending your life, please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

Reading on the website

More for your situation

- For teens: friends and pressure
- Family rifts · In-laws
- At work
- For teachers
- **Related chapters:** Belonging and trust (Chapter 4, page 63) · How we see each other (Chapter 3, page 47) · Values (Book 2, Chapter 7, page 125)
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
For teens: friends and pressure
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
In-laws
spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life



TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
For teachers
spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-teachers



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ The pull to fit in is old and strong.
- ✓ Authority can lead people a long way.
- ✓ Norms are the rules nobody wrote down.
- ✓ Online groups pull harder and faster.
- ✓ Disagree kindly, and early.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 3 · How we see each other page 47
Bias and the stories we tell

Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging page 63
Why belonging matters so much

Book 2, Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life Heal and Steady, page 125
Holding on to your own values

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair Share the Load, page 71
Agreeing what fair means in your group

PUT IT TO USE



The wiring card

To share how you work best so a group can make room for you

spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card



Leading a group

A six-session guide with ground rules that make room for difference

spreadloveandacceptance.com/groups



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-17-groups-in-depth

7

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 7

Helping others well: support without fixing, boundaries, and not burning out

How to help someone without taking over, by asking what they need, listening first, caring without drowning and keeping kind limits, with what to do in a crisis and how to keep going without burning out.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Ask what kind of help they want
2. Listening is a kind of help
3. Fixing it for them can take away their power
4. Care without drowning in their feelings
5. Your limits make your help last
6. Notice when you're running on empty
7. In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help
8. Don't wait for someone else to step in
9. Let other people help you too
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Ask what kind of help they want.** "Ideas, or just someone to listen?" saves a lot of misfires.
- **Listening is help.** Fixing a problem for someone can take away their power.

- **Your limits make your help last**, and caring from a steady place helps more than drowning in their feelings.
- **In a crisis, stay and bring in help.** It's okay to ask directly about suicide, and to call for help.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Two tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **One owner per job** (Book 4, Chapter 2 (page 27)) works for families sharing care because help lasts when it is shared and named, and carers burn out when everything counts as "just helping" and nobody else owns a job.
- **How much are you carrying?** (Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51)) helps you notice when you are running on empty before you snap or stop.

WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

Your friend is telling you about her awful week, and you have five good ideas before she has finished her first sentence. You share all of them. She goes quiet and says, "Yeah, maybe," and you both hang up feeling a little worse without quite knowing why.

Most of us want to help the people around us, and helping well is a skill, because good intentions don't always land. This chapter looks at how support works, why fixing can backfire and how to care for others in a way you can keep up, whether you are a friend, partner, parent, coworker, carer or neighbour.

01

Ask what kind of help they want.

Help comes in different kinds. Some people want ideas, some want someone to listen, some want a practical hand such as a meal or a lift, and some just want company. Giving the wrong kind, however kindly, can leave someone feeling unheard, and the simplest fix is to ask.

For example, in the phone call above, a better start might have been, “That sounds like a rotten week. Do you want ideas, or do you just want to vent?”

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> “Would ideas help, or would you rather I just listened?” “What would help most right now?”

TRY THIS.

Next time someone tells you about a problem, ask what kind of help they want before you give any.

02

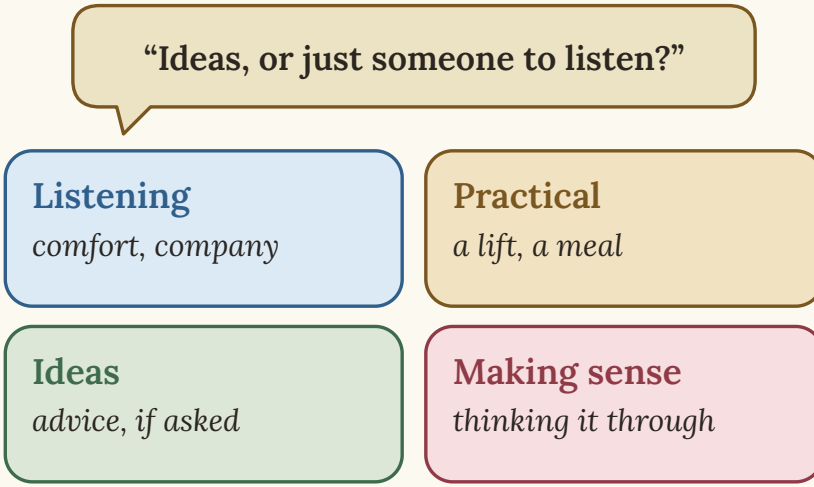
Listening is a kind of help.

Being truly heard helps people calm down, think more clearly and often find their own answers. Good listening means paying attention, letting them finish, checking you understood and showing that their feelings make sense, even if you would feel differently.

Ravi comes home upset about his boss. His partner resists saying “Just quit” and says, “So he criticised you in front of everyone, after you stayed late all week. No wonder you’re furious.” Ravi’s shoulders drop, and ten minutes later he is sketching out his own plan on the back of an envelope.

Ask what kind of help they want

The wrong kind of help can feel like not being heard.



- Fixing it for them can take away their power.
- Care from a steady place. Your limits make your help last.
- In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

Kinds of support after House (1981). Support helps most when it fits what the person needs (Cutrona and Russell, 1990), though the evidence for exact matching is mixed.

FIGURE 9 Ask what kind of help they want. Fixing it for them can take away their power, and your limits make your help last.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"So what happened was… Have I got that right?" "That makes sense. Anyone would feel that way."

THIS WEEK.

In one conversation today, listen for two whole minutes without giving advice, then sum up what you heard.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: sometimes the best help is sitting close and listening, no fixing needed. Listening takes energy too, so check your own tank now and then.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

03

Fixing it for them can take away their power.

When we love someone, we want to make the problem go away. Doing things for people that they could do themselves can leave them feeling less capable, though, so helping well often means helping someone do it themselves, which respects that it is their life and their choice.

For example, Rosalind's twenty-four-year-old son is struggling with a job application, and she itches to rewrite it. She asks instead whether he would like her to read it and say what stands out, and he makes the changes himself and is quietly proud when he gets the interview.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Is this mine to fix, or theirs to solve with my support?" "What do they want to do here?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Notice the urge to fix, and before acting ask, "Would you like me to do that, or help you do it?"

04

Care without drowning in their feelings.

Feeling someone's pain as if it were your own can wear you out fast. Researchers separate this "empathic distress" from compassion, which is warm concern from a steadier place, still caring deeply without sinking alongside the other person. A steady helper is more use than a second person drowning.

When Abi's housemate went through a breakup, Abi cried with her every night and stopped sleeping, and after a week she was exhausted. She stayed kind and present after that while taking breaks, and reminded herself that this was her housemate's pain to feel and hers to accompany.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I can be with them in this without making it mine." "I care, and I'm steady."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

After a heavy conversation, do something that brings you back to yourself, such as a walk, a shower or five slow breaths.

05

Your limits make your help last.

Saying yes to everything leads in the long run to resentment, exhaustion and eventually to not being able to help at all. Limits tell people what you can give, so your yes means something, and a kind no that comes with an offer of what you can do is still help.

For example, Kojo's sister keeps asking to borrow money. He loves her and he is running out, so he tells her, "I can't lend money any more. I can help you go through your bills on Sunday, if you'd like."

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I can't do that, but I can do this." "I want to help, and I need to stop at nine tonight."

TRY THIS.

Write down one thing you are giving that you can't keep giving, and plan a smaller version you could offer instead.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your limits keep your help going for longer. When you need to say "not this time", the Chat analyzer's "Help me write it" helps you say no kindly, with something to offer instead.

TOOL **Chat analyzer: Help me write it (say no kindly)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Chat analyzer: Help me write it (say no kindly)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

06

Notice when you're running on empty.

People who help a lot, such as carers, parents, nurses, teachers and the friend everyone calls, can burn out. The signs include feeling exhausted most of the time, feeling numb or cynical about the people you help, getting ill more often and dreading the next call, and they mean that you need help too.

Helen has looked after her husband since his stroke. She snaps at him and then feels terrible, and her doctor says it sounds like carer strain. A local carers' group and a few hours of respite each week give her back a little of herself.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
>
> "Looking after myself is part of looking after them."

THIS WEEK.

Rate your energy from 1 to 10 each evening for a week. If it's often 3 or lower, ask someone for one specific kind of help. See Caring for someone you love.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

07

In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

If someone tells you they're thinking of ending their life, or you're worried they might be, it's okay to ask them directly. Research, such as a review led by Tim Dazzi (2014), suggests asking about suicide doesn't put the idea in someone's head; it can bring relief. You don't have to be their therapist. Your job is to listen, stay with them, and help them reach trained support.

For example (a coworker): A colleague says, "Sometimes I think everyone would be better off without me." Kirsty says gently: "I'm really glad you told me. Are you thinking about ending your life?" She says she's had thoughts. Kirsty stays with her and they call a crisis line together.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "Are you thinking about suicide?" "I'm glad you told me. You don't have to go through this alone. Let's call someone together."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Save a crisis number in your phone now, so you have it if you ever need it. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If someone is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

08

Don't wait for someone else to step in.

When lots of people see something go wrong, each person can assume someone else will act. Psychologists call this the bystander effect, and knowing about it helps you break it. Small, safe actions

count, such as asking “Are you okay?”, getting staff or calling for help.

For example (a stranger): On a train, a man is making a young woman uncomfortable. Yvonne doesn’t confront him. She sits next to the woman and asks loudly, “Hi! Is this the train to Leeds?” The woman joins in the chat, and the man moves away.

YOU COULD SAY

“Are you okay? Do you need anything?” To someone else nearby: “Can you get the driver? I’ll stay here.”

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Think of one safe thing you could do if you saw someone in trouble in a public place, such as distracting, getting help or checking in afterwards, because having a plan makes it easier to act.

09

Let other people help you too.

Helping goes both ways, and people who are good at giving help are often bad at receiving it. Letting others help is a gift to them too, because most people like being useful to someone they care about, and relationships where only one person ever helps tend to feel uneven over time.

For example, Nkechi said “We’re fine, thanks” to every offer after the baby came. When she finally said yes to a neighbour’s offer of a lasagne, the neighbour was delighted, and these days they walk their buggies round the park together.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

“Yes, thank you. That would really help.” “Could you do one thing for me this week?”

TRY THIS.

Say yes to the next small offer of help you get, even if you could manage without it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

One owner per job: sharing the care

Margaret and Alan, with their daughter Sue

One owner per job: sharing the care

Person A
Margaret

Person B
Alan

Person C
Sue

Date of this list
6 October 2026

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Medicines and the pill box (as the care team directs)	*Weekly*	0.5	*Margaret*	*Sue*	*Sue checks it on Sundays*
Book and go along to medical appointments	*As needed*	3	*Sue*	*Margaret*	*Sue drives; Mum comes too*
Insurance and paperwork	*Monthly*	1	*Alan*	*Sue*	*Dad can do this from his chair*
Night care and night-time calls	*Daily*	1	*Margaret*		*Ask the nurse about a night sitter*

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Sunday call with the family	*Weekly*	0.5	*Alan*		
Book respite: a break for the main carer	*Monthly*	0.5	*Sue*		*Mum's Thursday afternoon off*
Groceries and meals	*Weekly*	2	*Sue*	*Margaret*	*Online shop, Sue orders*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
7 of 7. Every job has an owner.

Who's carrying more right now
Margaret 63% · Alan 9% · Sue 28%. Does this match what you agreed? If it doesn't match, ask which job could move first. It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

Changes to the list

Date	What changed	Who
6 Oct 2026	*Sue takes Tuesday nights from next week, so Margaret gets one full night's sleep.*	*Margaret, Alan and Sue*

This is about who owns each job, not medical advice.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (sharing the care)

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can offer help, listen well, and be honest about your limits. You can't make someone accept help, take your advice or get better on your timetable. Their life and their choices are theirs. If someone is in danger, your part is to bring in help, not to carry it alone.

THE NEXT WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

Your friend calls again, and this time you ask whether she wants ideas or just to talk it out. She laughs and says just talk, so you listen, through her manager, her landlord and the cat's vet bill. At the end she says she thinks she knows what she is going to do, and you realise you haven't offered a single idea.

In everyday life

Helping yourself counts too, and you can ask yourself the same question, whether you need ideas right now or just some rest. Caring for a parent or a child with extra needs is long-haul help, so share the load early (see Caring for someone you love). The friend everyone calls needs someone to call too. Covering for a struggling coworker is kind for a week, and after that it needs a real conversation with the team. In an emergency, point to one person,

as in “You in the blue coat, please call for help,” because a crowd often waits for someone else. If you have ADHD, helping can feel interesting and urgent, so a fast yes comes easily, and “I’d like to help. Let me check my week and come back to you tonight” gives you time. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

Common mix-ups

- **“Helping means solving the problem.”** Often, helping means listening, being there or helping someone find their own answer.
- **“Good helpers never say no.”** Good helpers last because they know their limits.
- **“Asking about suicide might give them the idea.”** Research suggests it doesn’t, and asking can help someone open up.
- **“I’ll make it worse if I step in.”** There are small, safe ways to help. Doing nothing often feels worse for the person in trouble.

If you want to help someone else with this

The helpers around you need looking after too.

- **Notice the helpers**, such as the carer, the friend everyone calls and the coworker who always covers, and ask them how they are as if you mean it.
- **Offer specific help.** "Can I take the kids on Saturday morning?" is easier to accept than "Let me know if you need anything."
- **Give them permission to rest.** "You're allowed a night off. I've got this."
- **If a helper seems burned out,** share Caring for someone you love or suggest they talk to a doctor.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "You look after everyone. Who looks after you?" "I'd love to do something for you this week. What would help?"

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

When to get more help

- **If someone is in danger now,** call your local emergency number.
- **If someone talks about suicide,** stay with them and contact a crisis line together. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

- **If someone tells you they're being hurt or controlled at home,** believe them, don't confront the other person yourself, and share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)
- **If you're burned out as a helper or carer,** talk to your doctor, a carers' organisation or a counsellor. Respite and support are not luxuries.
- **If helping someone is becoming unsafe for you,** step back and bring in professionals. You can still care from a safer distance.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Check-ins, for tender conversations, and Professor Puddles if you want help finding words.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Kitchen-table check-in
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/check-ins

TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/ask

More for your situation

- **Carers:** Caring for someone you love · When one of you is ill
- **Friends:** Friends
- **Parents and grandparents:** For parents · For grandparents · When a child has ADHD
- **At work:** At work · For counsellors, coaches and group leaders
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter is about everyday helping. It isn't training in crisis care or therapy. When someone's safety is at risk, the most helpful thing you can do is bring in people trained to help.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers



ONLINE
When one of you is ill
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill



ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends



ONLINE
For parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents



ONLINE
For grandparents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents



ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids



TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
For counsellors, coaches and group leaders
spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors



ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/grief



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4, Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees
The care work nobody sees
Share the Load, page 9

Book 4, Chapter 2 · Is the split working?
Sharing the load so it lasts
Share the Load, page 27

Book 2, Chapter 4 · Loss, grief and big life changes
Helping someone through grief
Heal and Steady, page 73

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system
Noticing your own stress first
Heal and Steady, page 9

PUT IT TO USE



Check-ins

For tender conversations, and Professor Puddles if you want help finding words

spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins



Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles

spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping-in-depth

Words for hard moments

Some ways to say the hard parts, collected in one place. Change the words until they sound like you.

TO BEGIN

> "Is now a good time to talk about Saturday, or would tomorrow be better?"
>
> "Something has been on my mind, and I'd rather tell you than let it grow."
>
> "I'd like to understand how it looked from your side."

TO CHECK WHAT THEY MEANT

> "When you said 'fine', did you mean fine, or not really?"
>
> "Can I check I've got this right?"
>
> "What did you hear me say?"

TO PAUSE

> "I need twenty minutes. I'll come back at half past."
>
> "I'm not going anywhere. I just need some quiet."

TO PUT IT RIGHT

> "That came out wrong. Can I try again?"
>
> "I think we both meant well, and it still went sideways."
>
> "I'm sorry I was sharp with you earlier."

WHEN SOMEONE IS STRUGGLING

> "Do you want ideas, or would you like me to just listen?"
>
> "That sounds hard. Tell me more."
>
> "I can do Tuesday evenings. Who else could we ask?"

Questions people ask

Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.

We care about each other but keep falling out. Where do we start?

Start with pace. Two people who both care can still run at different speeds, talk things through at different times and feel urgency about different things. Why we get out of tune (Chapter 1, page 9) helps you spot which one is catching you, and the workpaper Same moment, different speeds lets you compare your answers side by side.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-12 · free to print
Same moment, different speeds
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-12

Our messages keep going wrong. Any quick fixes?

Read a message twice before you reply, and assume the warmest tone that fits the words. Short texts lose their tone on the way, so a quick "Do you mean…?" saves a lot. How communication works (Chapter 2, page 27) covers this, and the Chat analyzer on the website lets you check how a message may land before you send it.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Chat analyzer
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

My family remember things completely differently from me. Who is right?

Often both of you, a little. Memory keeps what mattered to each person and quietly fills in the rest. How we see each other (Chapter 3, page **47**) explains why, and suggests asking "What do you remember about that day?" before you share your own version.

How do I help someone without wearing myself out?

Ask what kind of help they want, do the part you can keep doing, and say plainly where your limit is. Help that lasts usually comes from more than one person. Helping others well (Chapter 7, page **115**) has a part on noticing when you are running on empty.

I feel like I don't quite belong anywhere. Is something wrong with me?

No. Feeling on the edge of a group is common, especially after a move, a breakup or a change of job. Belonging tends to grow from small, repeated contact with the same few people. Attachment, trust and belonging (Chapter 4, page **63**) and Groups, influence and culture (Chapter 6, page **97**) both have ideas to try.

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

In: Helping others well (page 115)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

In: Why we get out of tune (page 9), How communication works (page 27), Groups, influence and culture (page 97)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13

In: Why we get out of tune (page 9)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page 63), Closeness and love (page 81)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

In: How communication works (page 27), How we see each other (page 47), Groups, influence and culture (page 97)

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: How communication works (page 27), How we see each other (page 47)

TOOL **Chat analyzer: Help me write it (say no kindly)** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals`
In: Helping others well (page **115**)

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins`
In: Helping others well (page **115**)

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding`
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page **63**), Closeness and love (page **81**)

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages`
In: Closeness and love (page **81**)

TOOL **How you connect: how to talk to me** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card`
In: Groups, influence and culture (page **97**)

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration`
In: Why we get out of tune (page **9**)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask`
In: Helping others well (page **115**)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

Calm-Down Kit
The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Carrier wave
The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Complacency
Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

Drift
Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

Flooded
Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Frequency
Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

Kinship care
When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load
The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

My weather today
My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Person A and Person B

Person A and Person B are simply the two people on a two-person worksheet or tool. They are labels, not a ranking.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes



The 125 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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